LINKEDIN
ALGORITHM AUDIT KIT

8 rules to align your profile and content with LinkedIn's rebuilt AI-powered feed

Based on LinkedIn's arXiv research paper (Oct 2025), engineering blog (Mar 2026), official corporate announcement (Mar 2026), and VP of Engineering disclosures

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HOW LINKEDIN'S ALGORITHM ACTUALLY WORKS NOW

In March 2026, LinkedIn publicly confirmed a ground-up rebuild of the system that decides what content appears in your feed. The old architecture used multiple separate systems running in parallel (trending topics, collaborative filtering, embedding-based retrieval). Each could be gamed independently.

The new system has two layers:

1. Retrieval: A unified model powered by a fine-tuned large language model (Meta's LLaMA 3) that matches content to viewers based on semantic meaning, not keywords.

2. Ranking: A Generative Recommender that treats your feed history as a sequence, processing 1,000+ historical interactions to understand your professional interests over time.

> **KEY DISTINCTION:** Only 5 fields from your profile travel with your content into someone else's feed: Name, Headline, Company, Industry, and Title. This is your "author data." Your full profile (skills, job history, education, certifications, languages) is used on the VIEWER side to understand what they want to see. Your engagement with other posts does NOT affect whether your content reaches someone else 3 it only shapes your own feed. (Correction confirmed by Adam Bird, Senior AI/ML Leader)

> **COMMON MISTAKE:** Many LinkedIn guides say "the algorithm reads your entire profile before distributing your content." This is inaccurate. Only your author data (5 fields) is encoded on the content side. The rest is used on the viewer side.

SECTION 1: PROFILE-CONTENT ALIGNMENT SCORECARD

Your author data (name, headline, company, industry, title) is what the AI uses to match your content to the right audience. If these fields don't align with what you actually post about, the system can't deliver your content to the right people.

The AI reads 5 fields from your profile on the content side: Name, Headline, Company, Industry, and Title. These are the fields that travel with every post you publish. Audit each one.

Author Data Audit (The 5 Fields That Travel With Your Content)

1. Headline

Does your headline contain the language your ideal client uses to describe what they need?	Y / N	

Does it specify your niche clearly enough for an AI to match you to the right audience?	Y / N	

Would a stranger immediately know what you do and who you help?	Y / N	

2. Company

Is your company name filled in and accurate?	Y / N	

Does the company name carry a meaningful signal? (e.g., "Distinctiva" is less informative to the AI than "Distinctiva ⟶ B2B Content Agency")	Y / N	

3. Industry

Is your industry field set to the most specific option LinkedIn offers?	Y / N	

Does it match the topics you post about? (If you post about marketing but your industry says "Information Technology," the AI gets a mixed signal)	Y / N	

4. Title

Does your title field reflect what you actually do, not just a generic role like “Founder” or “Consultant”?	Y / N	

Would the AI understand your expertise from your title alone?	Y / N	

5. Name

Is your name consistent with how you’re known professionally? (This matters less for matching but affects recognition)	Y / N	

Content Alignment Check

Do 8 out of 10 of your recent posts map to the same 2–3 topic areas?	Y / N	

Does your About section describe the problem you solve in your ICP’s language?	Y / N	

Do your Featured posts reinforce your core topics (not random viral posts)?	Y / N	

Scoring: 11–14 Yes = Strong alignment. 8–10 Yes = Fixable gaps. Below 8 = Your author data is likely limiting your distribution.

Headline Rewrite Framework

Your headline should contain the words your ideal client would use to describe what they need. Not what you do. What they need.

> **COMMON MISTAKE:** Don’t keyword-stuff your headline with pipes. The AI reads semantic meaning, not keyword lists. “B2B Content Strategist | LinkedIn Growth | Content Systems” is keyword logic from the old system. Write a headline that reads as one coherent professional identity.

Example 1

BAD: “Helping companies grow | Advisor | Thought Leader | Speaker”

GOOD: “Fractional CFO for B2B startups raising Series A to B | Financial modeling & investor readiness”

Example 2

BAD: “Entrepreneur | Innovator | Building the future | Passionate about tech”

GOOD: “Helping Series A SaaS teams reduce churn by 30% through customer onboarding systems | Founder, [Company]”

Notice the pattern: the BAD examples use vague labels that could apply to anyone. The GOOD examples name the buyer, the problem, and the outcome. The AI can match the good examples to the right viewer profiles. The bad examples are unmatchable.

Your Headline

Write your current headline here:

Rewrite it with your ICP’s language:

🤖 AI PROMPT 3 Rewrite Your Headline

```
LinkedIn’s algorithm reads 5 fields from your profile when deciding who sees your content:
Name, Headline, Company, Industry, and Title. The system uses a large language model that
understands semantic meaning, not keywords.Here is my current LinkedIn headline: [PASTE
YOUR HEADLINE]My current company field: [PASTE COMPANY]My current industry field: [PASTE
INDUSTRY]My current title field: [PASTE TITLE]My ideal client is: [DESCRIBE YOUR ICP  3
their role, industry, and the problem you solve for them]Analyze all 4 fields (not name)
and tell me:1. What semantic signal would an AI extract from each field right now?2. Where
are the mismatches between my fields and my ICP?3. Give me 5 rewritten headlines ranked by
specificity. Each should read as one coherent professional identity, not a keyword list.
Keep under 120 characters.4. Recommend changes to my Company, Industry, and Title fields
if they’re diluting my signal.5. For each headline option, explain which viewer profiles
it would match against and why.
```

SECTION 2: YOUR FIRST 50 WORDS

In LinkedIn's tested model configuration, the retrieval system truncates post text to the first 60 tokens (roughly 45 words) when deciding whether to include you in the candidate pool. Everything after that matters for ranking, but the initial filter focuses on the beginning.

> **FROM THE PAPER:** The arXiv paper (Section 8.6) states: "all post texts in the query and item side were truncated to the first 60 tokens." This was the configuration that improved recall by 15%. Your opening words carry disproportionate weight.

Audit Checklist

- ☐ **Do your first 50 words contain your topic?**
  The AI needs to know what this post is about from the opening.

- ☐ **Do your first 50 words signal your audience?**
  Who is this for? The AI matches content to viewer profiles.

- ☐ **Could your opening belong to anyone in your industry?**
  If yes, it's too generic. Add specificity.

Audit Your Last 5 Posts

Post 1 3 first 50 words. Enough signal? Y / N

Post 2 3 first 50 words. Enough signal? Y / N

Post 3 3 first 50 words. Enough signal? Y / N

Post 4 3 first 50 words. Enough signal? Y / N

Post 5 3 first 50 words. Enough signal? Y / N

🤖 AI PROMPT 3 Audit Your Hooks

```
LinkedIn’s retrieval system truncates post text to the first 60 tokens (roughly 45 words)
when deciding whether to show your post to someone. The AI needs to identify your topic
AND your audience within those first 45 words.I’m going to paste the first 50 words of my
last 5 LinkedIn posts. My ideal client is: [DESCRIBE ICP]For each post, tell me:1. What
topic does the AI detect in these opening words?2. What audience does it match to? Be
specific about job titles and industries.3. Semantic signal strength: Strong / Moderate /
Weak. Explain why.4. What’s missing from the opening that would help the AI match
better?5. Rewrite the hook to front-load topic + audience within 45 words. Keep my
voice.Post 1: [PASTE]Post 2: [PASTE]Post 3: [PASTE]Post 4: [PASTE]Post 5: [PASTE]After
analyzing all 5, give me a pattern diagnosis: Am I consistently front-loading signal, or
do I have a habit of burying it?
```

SECTION 3: GO DEEP OR GO INVISIBLE

The new LLM uses world knowledge to understand semantic connections between topics that keyword systems couldn't see. If you try to be about everything, the AI can't build a clear embedding for you. But if you go deep on a specific topic, the system gets extremely good at finding the right audience.

> **FROM THE ENGINEERING BLOG:** LinkedIn's example: if you're an electrical engineer who engages with posts about small modular reactors, the old system couldn't connect those. The new system understands the semantic relationship through world knowledge. Tim Jurka (VP of Engineering): "Exceptional content may even be distributed broadly to members interested in the type of content you post, even if they don't follow you."

Audit Checklist

- ☐ **Can you identify a clear topical pattern in your last 20 posts?**
  Look at your recent content. Would the AI see a coherent signal?

- ☐ **Have you committed to a topic lane for 90+ days?**
  The algorithm builds your content fingerprint over time. Consistency matters.

- ☐ **Are you posting outside your lane more than 10% of the time?**
  Personal content is fine at ~10%. Random topics dilute your signal.

Define Your Lane

My primary topic (what I want to be known for):

3 subtopics within that lane:

Topics I will stop posting about:

🤖 AI PROMPT 3 Find Your Content Lane

```
LinkedIn’s algorithm builds a semantic embedding of you as a creator over time based on
what you post. If your topics are scattered, the embedding is vague and the system can’t
match you to the right audience. If you’re consistent, the embedding is sharp and
distribution improves.Here are the topics of my last 20 LinkedIn posts (one line
each):[PASTE POST TOPICS OR HEADLINES]My expertise is in: [YOUR FIELD]My ideal client is:
[DESCRIBE ICP]Analyze these posts and tell me:1. If you were an AI building an embedding
of me as a creator, what 3 topics would define it? How confident would you be in that
categorization (1-10)?2. Which posts are off-topic and actively diluting my embedding?
List them.3. What specific content lane should I commit to for the next 90 days? Be
precise  3 not just “marketing” but the exact niche within it.4. Give me 3 subtopics
within that lane to create variety without losing focus.5. Give me 10 specific post ideas
within this lane, each with a working title.6. What topics should I explicitly stop
posting about?
```

SECTION 4: WRITE POSTS THAT EARN SAVES

AuthoredUp's analysis found that one save equals roughly 5x the reach impact of a single like. The system is optimized for Professional Interactors 3 people who take meaningful actions like long dwells, saves, comments, and reshares.

> **FROM THE PAPER:** LinkedIn's optimization target is "daily unique Professional Interactors" 3 members who take meaningful actions (long dwell, react, comment, repost). The system is specifically built to find and reward this behavior.

Pre-Publish Filter

- ☐ **Would your ICP bookmark this post?**
  If not, add a framework, data set, or step-by-step breakdown.

- ☐ **Would they send it to a colleague?**
  Shareability is a strong signal of professional value.

- ☐ **Does your post contain something reusable?**
  Checklists, templates, formulas, specific numbers.

- ☐ **If you remove all opinion and story, is there still something actionable left?**
  Opinion gets likes. Tactical value gets saves.

What Gets Saved vs. What Gets Liked

✅ Gets Saved: Frameworks with named steps. Step-by-step sequences. Data with specific numbers. Checklists and templates. Tactical how-to breakdowns.

❌ Gets Liked Only: Opinions without structure. Motivational takes. Personal stories without takeaways. "Agree or disagree?" prompts. Generic industry commentary.

> 🤖 **AI PROMPT 3 Make Your Post Save-Worthy**
>
> ```
> LinkedIn's algorithm is optimized to find "Professional Interactors"  3 people who take
> high-intent actions like saving, commenting thoughtfully, and resharing. One save has
> roughly 5x the reach impact of a like. The system rewards content that earns these
> ```

```
meaningful actions.Here is my LinkedIn post draft:[PASTE YOUR POST]My ideal client is:
[DESCRIBE ICP]Analyze this post and tell me:1. Save test: Would a busy [ICP role] bookmark
this to reference later? Why or why not? Be brutally honest.2. Share test: Would they send
this to a colleague with a note saying "you need to read this"? Why or why not?3. What's
the single most save-worthy element you could add? Choose one: a named framework, a
specific data point, a step-by-step checklist, a template, or a comparison table.4.
Rewrite the post with that element integrated naturally. Keep my voice and tone. Don't
make it longer than necessary.5. Rate the original vs rewritten version on a
save-likelihood scale of 1-10.
```

SECTION 5: EARLY ENGAGEMENT 3 QUALITY OVER VELOCITY

LinkedIn converts raw engagement numbers into percentile buckets. The system sees “71st percentile of view counts” not “12,345 views.” This change improved the model’s correlation with relevance by 30x and recall by 15%.

Early engagement matters because it moves your post into a higher popularity percentile, making the AI more confident about broader distribution. But the engagement must be genuine.

> **COMMON MISTAKE:** Pods and fake early engagement are counterproductive. LinkedIn’s March 2026 announcement explicitly states they are working to make engagement pods ineffective. The system tracks dwell time and distinguishes real engagement from performative engagement.

Audit Checklist

- ☐ **Is your hook strong enough to earn organic first engagement?**
  Don’t rely on pods. Write hooks that stop the scroll.

- ☐ **Do you reply to every comment in the first 2 hours?**
  Real conversations signal genuine professional interaction to the system.

- ☐ **Are your comments substantive (3+ sentences)?**
  One-word replies don’t generate engagement depth.

🤖 AI PROMPT 3 Write a Scroll-Stopping Hook

```
LinkedIn’s retrieval system reads only the first 60 tokens (~45 words) of your post when
deciding whether to show it to someone. The hook has two jobs: (1) stop a human from
scrolling, and (2) give the AI enough semantic signal to match you to the right
audience.I’m writing a LinkedIn post about: [YOUR TOPIC]My target audience is: [DESCRIBE
ICP  3 role, industry, pain point]The main insight or takeaway of the post is: [ONE
SENTENCE SUMMARY]Give me 10 hook options (first 2-3 lines only, before the “see more”
fold). For each hook:1. Write the hook text (keep under 45 words)2. Label the technique
used (contradiction, specificity, question, bold claim, story opener, data lead)3. What
semantic signal does the AI extract from this hook?4. Why would a [ICP role] stop
scrolling for this?Rank all 10 by predicted engagement strength. Then give me your top 3
with a brief explanation of why each would outperform the others.
```

SECTION 6: YOUR ENGAGEMENT HISTORY TRAINS YOUR FEED

The system maintains a time-ordered list of every post you've positively engaged with. Negative signals (posts you scrolled past) are excluded 3 they actually hurt model performance. Removing them reduced memory by 37%, processed 40% more training data per batch, and trained 2.6x faster.

The Generative Recommender treats your history as a sequence. It understands that engaging with machine learning content Monday, distributed systems Tuesday, and opening LinkedIn Wednesday is a learning journey, not random clicks.

> **IMPORTANT DISTINCTION:** Your engagement with other people's posts does NOT affect whether YOUR content reaches someone else. It only shapes what appears in YOUR feed. But your feed shapes what inspires your content. And what you create is what the algorithm distributes.

Audit Checklist

- ☐ **Are you engaging with content in your niche daily?**
  Like, comment, save posts from creators in your topic area.

- ☐ **Are you accidentally training your feed with off-topic engagement?**
  Random likes on motivational posts = more random content in your feed.

- ☐ **Are you following creators who produce the kind of content you want to create?**
  Your feed is your creative fuel. Curate it intentionally.

🤖 AI PROMPT 3 Curate Your Feed Strategy

```
LinkedIn's algorithm maintains a time-ordered list of every post you've positively engaged
with. It uses this to understand your professional interests and serve you more relevant
content. What you engage with shapes your feed, which shapes what inspires your own
content.I work in: [YOUR INDUSTRY]My content focuses on: [YOUR TOPIC]My ideal client is:
[DESCRIBE ICP]Help me build a feed curation strategy:1. Give me 15 LinkedIn creators I
should actively engage with daily. For each one, tell me their name, what they post about,
and why engaging with their content specifically trains my feed toward my niche.2. What 5
types of content should I STOP engaging with? (e.g., motivational quotes, off-topic viral
posts). Explain how each one dilutes my feed signal.3. Give me a daily 15-minute feed
engagement routine: what to do first, how many posts to engage with, what kind of comments
to leave.4. How should I use the "save" feature strategically to train my feed faster?
```

SECTION 7: PODS AND ENGAGEMENT BAIT ARE DEAD

LinkedIn's official announcement on March 12, 2026 states directly: they are working to make engagement pods ineffective and curb comment automation and third-party tools that create fake conversations. They are reducing repetitive, low-substance posts and engagement bait.

The system tracks dwell time and genuine engagement patterns. It distinguishes between someone who read your post and left a thoughtful comment versus someone who typed "great insight" in two seconds without reading.

Audit Checklist

- ☐ **Are you in any engagement pods?**
  If yes, leave them. The system is specifically designed to detect this.

- ☐ **Are you using comment automation tools?**
  If yes, stop. LinkedIn named this explicitly in their announcement.

- ☐ **Are any of your posts designed to game distribution?**
  "Comment AGREE if..." or mismatched captions are specifically flagged.

- ☐ **Could you defend every post as genuinely valuable?**
  If not, the system will figure that out.

🤖 **AI PROMPT 3 Audit for Engagement Bait**

```
LinkedIn's March 2026 official announcement says they are specifically targeting:
engagement pods, comment automation tools, "comment AGREE" prompts, repetitive
low-substance posts, and videos where the caption doesn't match the content. The system
tracks dwell time and distinguishes genuine engagement from performative engagement.Here
are my last 10 LinkedIn posts:[PASTE YOUR POSTS 3 full text of each]For each post,
evaluate:1. BAIT CHECK: Is this post designed primarily to generate engagement, or to
deliver genuine value? Be honest.2. HOOK-CONTENT MATCH: Does the hook promise something
the post actually delivers? Flag any mismatch.3. CTA CHECK: Does the call to action ask
for genuine engagement, or is it a gaming tactic? ("Comment if you agree" = gaming.
"What's your experience with this?" = genuine.)4. DWELL CHECK: Would someone actually stop
and read this, or would they engage without reading?5. VERDICT: Would LinkedIn's new
system likely boost, ignore, or actively suppress this post? Explain why.After all 10,
give me:- My overall bait score (percentage of posts that have bait patterns)- The #1
pattern I need to break- A rewritten CTA template I can use instead
```

SECTION 8: SMALLER ACCOUNTS HAVE A STRUCTURAL ADVANTAGE

LinkedIn's A/B test data shows the new system produced a 3.29% revenue increase for members with fewer connections and a 1.17% increase in professional interactions. The biggest beneficiaries are smaller, newer accounts.

Shield Analytics Benchmarks (February 2026)

Median impressions per post by follower count:

0–1K followers: 148 impressions

1–5K followers: 479 impressions

5–10K followers: 774 impressions

10–25K followers: 1,216 impressions

25–50K followers: 2,143 impressions

50–100K followers: 5,144 impressions

100K+ followers: 12,520 impressions

These are medians. The top 10% and top 1% travel much further. Source: Andreas Jonsson, CEO of Shield Analytics, February 2026.

Audit Checklist

- ☐ **Have you stopped waiting to "build a bigger audience"?**
  The system just got rebuilt in your favor. Start now.

- ☐ **Are you posting at least 3x per week consistently?**
  Consistency feeds the algorithm's ability to categorize you.

- ☐ **Are you tracking quality metrics, not just follower count?**
  Saves, comments from ICP, DMs, and conversions matter more than impressions.

🤖 **AI PROMPT 3 Build Your 90-Day Content Plan**

```
I'm building (or rebuilding) my LinkedIn presence. LinkedIn's new algorithm rewards depth
over breadth, genuine engagement over velocity, and saves over likes. It matches content
to viewers using semantic understanding, not keywords.My expertise is: [YOUR FIELD]My
```

```
ideal client is: [DESCRIBE ICP  3 role, industry, pain point]My content lane is: [YOUR
TOPIC from the exercise in Section 3]My current posting frequency: [e.g., 0, 1x/week,
3x/week]Time I can spend daily on LinkedIn: [e.g., 30 minutes]Build me a complete 90-day
plan:WEEK 1 (FOUNDATION):- Profile optimization checklist (what to change in my 5 author
data fields)- Daily commenting routine (how many, where, what kind)- Content planning for
my first postWEEKS 2-4 (BUILD CADENCE):- Posting schedule (which days, what times)-
Content mix: 35% growth posts, 35% authority posts, 20% conversion posts, 10% personal
posts. Give me 3 specific post ideas for each category.- Commenting strategy alongside
postingWEEKS 5-12 (SUSTAIN AND OPTIMIZE):- How to track what’s working (which metrics
matter, which don’t)- When to double down vs. adjust- 20 more post ideas organized by
content type- How to turn top-performing posts into saves (repurposing into frameworks,
checklists)Make this realistic. Don’t give me a plan that requires 3 hours a day. I need
something I’ll actually stick to.
```

THE RECOVERY SEQUENCE

If your reach has dropped and hasn't recovered, follow this week-by-week plan. The system refreshes embeddings within 30 minutes and indexes new posts within 1 minute, but building a consistent content signal takes sustained effort.

Week 1: Reset

Stop posting. Deep-clean your profile for alignment using the scorecard in Section 1. Rewrite your headline using your ICP's language. Update your About section. Spend 30 minutes per day leaving substantive comments on posts from creators in your niche. You're reshaping what the algorithm shows you, which reshapes what inspires your content.

Week 2: One Post

Post once. One piece of genuinely save-worthy content: a framework, data-backed insight, or step-by-step breakdown. Reply to every comment within 2 hours. This post needs real engagement depth.

Weeks 3–4: Build Cadence

Return to 2–3 posts per week. All tightly aligned to your core topic. No topic chaos. Continue daily commenting on niche-relevant posts. Monitor saves and comment quality, not just impressions.

Weeks 5–12: Sustain

Maintain the cadence. The system builds your content fingerprint over time through consistent signals. Stay in your lane. Don't chase viral topics outside your topic area. Track whether your engagement is coming from your ICP or from random audiences.

> **COMMON MISTAKE:** There is no magic reset button. The system continuously updates (embeddings refresh in 30 minutes, new posts indexed in 1 minute) but building authority in a topic takes consistent, aligned content over weeks. Don't expect overnight results.

YOUR COMPLETE CHECKLIST

1. Rewrite your headline with your ICP's language 3 for humans and the AI

2. Check your first 50 words on every post 3 front-load semantic signal

3. Pick a clear topic lane and commit for 90 days 3 depth over breadth

4. Write posts that earn saves 3 frameworks, data, playbooks

5. Focus on real early engagement 3 quality over velocity

6. Be intentional about what you engage with 3 curate your feed

7. Get out of pods and stop using automation 3 the system detects it

8. Start posting now regardless of audience size 3 the playing field just got flatter

SOURCES

• arXiv:2510.14223 – Large Scale Retrieval for the LinkedIn Feed using Causal Language Models (October 2025)

• LinkedIn Engineering Blog – Engineering the Next Generation of LinkedIn's Feed, Hristo Danchev (March 12, 2026)

• LinkedIn Corporate Communications – How LinkedIn Is Improving the Feed (March 12, 2026)

• Tim Jurka (VP of Engineering) – How Does the LinkedIn Feed Work? (August 2025)

• Adam Bird (Senior AI/ML Leader) – Corrections on author data vs. full profile scope

• Shield Analytics – February 2026 benchmarks, Andreas Jonsson (CEO)

• AuthoredUp – Engagement impact analysis (saves vs. likes)

COMMON MISTAKE: This kit does NOT cite the 360Brew paper (arXiv:2501.16450) as a source for how the current system works. 360Brew is a separate 150B-parameter foundation model described in a paper that was withdrawn for licensing reasons. The retrieval system described in this kit is the GPU-RAR system from the October 2025 paper, confirmed by the March 2026 engineering blog.

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